

BASIC POSITIONING AND TECHNIQUE FOR GUITAR

Posture:

- Use an armless chair with a relatively flat seat.
- Sit on the front half of the chair with feet flat on the ground. Your left foot (right foot if you are playing a dreadnought guitar) should be on the footstool if you are not using a strap or alternative support device.
- Keep in mind that just about every joint in your body will be in its neutral state in the middle of its range of motion. If we find the middle or neutral state of the pelvic joint, and allow the sitting bones to connect with the chair, everything above will naturally stack on top of that stable base.
- Your back should be relaxed and upright, shoulders square and relaxed, head “floating” upward; be aware of craning of the neck or hunching of the shoulders.
- With the shoulders relaxed and neutral and left arm hanging loose, bend the elbow slightly more than 90° to raise the hand, with the palm facing out. This is where your body wants the guitar neck to be!
- The guitar should be positioned so that the bottom of the headstock is just about at eye level. This should position the neck such that the guitar neck meets the hand in the position described above, with the first finger at the third fret or so. Adjust your footstool, strap, or other support accordingly.
- With a footstool, the guitar should contact the body in three places: the left leg, the right leg and the chest- just let the guitar balance here, there’s no need to compress the body to keep it in place.
- For the most part, look to the guitar with the eyes and by pivoting the head from the top of the spine- avoid craning the neck to look at the guitar. Remember, you really only need to see the profile of the neck to know what fret you’re on.

Finger Independence “Games” For Left and Right Hands:

- Remember that the wrist and forearm, together, can provide three types of motion: 1) flexion/extension of the wrist 2) adduction (ulnar deviation) and abduction (radial deviation) of the wrist 3) pronation and supination of forearm and hand. We want to find the neutral state of all of these axes of movement and make this our default state when approaching the guitar.
- Find the “neutral” position of the hand, using one or all of the following methods:
 - Imagine your hand is cupping, or draped over a ball the size of a lemon or small orange.
 - Shake your lower arms, and hands, letting them flop. Observe the shape to which the hand and fingers naturally return.
 - With wrists neutral, alternate between making a fist (flexing joints of hand) and fully stretching of expanding the hand (extending joints of hand), allowing the hand to passively fall back to neutral each time. After a few rounds, the hand should return to the “draped over the orange” shape.
- Starting with the index finger, attempt to move each finger independently, from the top joint or knuckle (metacarpophalangeal joint). This may be counterintuitive, but the top joint has the greatest potential for independence of all the joints of the finger. Though we won’t extend beyond neutral in normal playing situations, exploring the full range

of motion (flexion and extension) will help you develop control over big joint motion and proper mechanics. Try these tricks for isolating movement from the top joint:

- Beginning with the neutral “holding the lemon” shape, move each finger, concentrating on maintaining the *neutral* curve of the fingers.
- Attempt to touch the crease of the wrist joint with the tip of your finger. You won’t actually be able to do this, but it will force you to move from the top joint. You may have the feeling of *pushing* the fingertip, which will come in handy when we deal with finger style technique.
- Try to squeeze a fat marker between the top segment (proximal phalanx) and your palm.
- For the thumb, try to push the tip of the thumb to the outside of the index finger.
- Once you’ve gotten the hang of top joint movement, try the following with each finger:
 - Move finger in- just enough for the middle joint to clear the neighboring finger’s middle joint- and out in a continuous, controlled manner.
 - Move finger in- just enough for the middle joint to clear the neighboring finger’s middle joint- hold for a moment, then release tension and let finger passively spring back to neutral
- Attempt to maintain other fingers in their neutral state. It may help to jiggle the other fingers, especially the tip joints, to increase awareness and encourage independence, but never force a finger to remain still.

Right Hand, Pick-Style:

- Rest the right arm lightly on the guitar just below the elbow, so the hand naturally hovers over the strings, roughly over the third of the sound hole closest to the bridge.
- Your wrist should also be neutral, right in between fully extended and fully flexed.
- Keeping the fingers neutral, place the pick on the *side* of the index finger (not the pad), roughly parallel to the middle phalanx.
- Allow the thumb to *flop* over the pick, with roughly 1/4” of the pick sticking out below the thumb. The pick is now held securely between the pad of the thumb and the side of the distal phalanx of the index finger. This might take some getting used to, so it might help to carry a pick around with you and to experiment with this, away from the guitar. Explore just how little pressure is needed to keep the pick in place.
- The principle impulse for strumming or picking- for now- will come from the elbow. Allow the lower arm and hand to move smoothly and steadily, like a pendulum swinging.
- As your ‘picking pendulum’ is swinging away, check in with your arms, shoulders, neck, etc... to make sure they are all staying as relaxed as possible, in a state of *dynamic* as opposed to *static* tension.
- Use the pendulum analogy to strum some open strings, then slowly shorten the arc to pick just a single string.
- Observe that slightly more pressure will be needed to hold the pick in place as the pick passes through the string, but that it can be released once the string and pick part ways.
- The most clear, full sound for picking single notes will be achieved with the pick perpendicular to the plane of the strings, so that the hand is parallel to the plane of the strings. This will be our “default” position.
- Begin to explore the first page of *Right and Left Hand Exercises*.

Left Hand:

- Beginning with the left arm hanging from the shoulder, find the relaxed state of the hand; again, it should look as if you are holding a lemon or small orange.
- Raise the lower arm from the elbow until it meets the neck, as described above. If need to adjust the height of the guitar to make this happen, do so. Don't twist your body or arms to bring you body to the guitar, let the guitar come to you.
- Allow the *tips* of the fingers to contact the high (sounding) E string, at frets 5-8. The fingers should line up roughly in the middle of the space between frets. Just rest the fingers on the strings for now, don't apply weight or pressure.
- Allow the wrist to be just slightly flexed.
- Observe where the thumb wants to contact the back of the neck. If the hand is in its relaxed neutral state, the thumb should meet the back of the neck just below the centerline, roughly opposite the second finger. The bony side of the thumb touches the next, not the pad.
- Allow the hand and wrist to move forward just a bit, so the fingers are hovering just above the strings when in their neutral state. This is our starting point.
- Before you begin the left hand exercises from *Right and Left Hand Exercises*, explore the following:

Exercises for Economy and Efficient Release of Tension:**“Clunk, Buzz, Note”**

- Begin by very slowly (half notes at 60BPM to start) playing a 4-note chromatic scale on frets 5 through 8, using one finger per fret.
- Now do the same, but without pressing the string down to the metal of the fret. Each finger will gently rest on the string, in turn, creating a “clunk” sound when the string is picked. Experiment with this for a while.
- Now, apply more pressure, a little at a time, until you get a sustained “buzzy” note. This is the threshold pressure, between insufficient and just right.
- Next, dial up the tension just a bit until you get clear/clean notes.
- Try this exercise on all strings and in different positions. Make a note of how this feels and return to this exercise often. Most of us initially use too much pressure when playing, so this can be very illuminating!

“Pulsing”

- Again, play a very slow 4-note chromatic scale in half notes
- Now play alternating between quarter notes and quarter note rests.
- On the downbeat of the rest beat, simply release tension and allow the finger to spring back up. It may help to think of the string pushing the finger away from the fingerboard.
- Experiment with this for a while, then return to *legato* quarter notes, trying to incorporate the feeling of release at the moment of finger exchange.
- Use this exercise with scale passages, chord exchanges, or any other topic.

For more detailed and in depth information about technique and posture, check out:

- David Leisner, *Playing with Ease: A Healthy Approach to Guitar Technique* (Oxford UP, 2018)
- Scott Tennant, *Pumping Nylon: The Classical Guitarist's Technique Handbook* (Alfred Music, 2016)

RIGHT HAND POSITION WITH PICK



RIGHT HAND POSITION- FINGER-STYLE

